HAWAII

The Aloha State



The Polynesian voyagers who settled the Hawaiian Islands arrived sometime between 400 and 800 CE, navigating thousands of open-ocean miles by star, wave, and wind in double-hulled canoes. They carried everything they needed to build a new life—taro, sweet potato, breadfruit, chickens, and pigs. That pig would become one of the most important ingredients in Hawaiian culinary history, not merely as food but as the centerpiece of a tradition that has endured for more than a thousand years.

The method they developed was the imu, an underground oven dug into volcanic soil. Dense basalt stones were heated until they glowed, then lined the pit and were layered with banana and ti leaves. The pig, seasoned with pa'akai—Hawaiian sea salt harvested from coastal pans—was set whole into the earth, wrapped to seal in the steam, and covered over. Then came the waiting: hours of slow, fragrant, underground transformation. What emerged was Kalua pork, the flesh bathed in steam and smoke and mineral warmth until it pulled apart effortlessly, deeply smoky and impossibly tender. It was food that tasted like the place that made it.

The imu was never an everyday method. It was communal and deeply tied to 'ohana—family—marking births, comings-of-age, marriages, and triumphs. The ali'i held great feasts where the pork was always the honored centerpiece, served alongside poi, lomi salmon, and haupia amid music and hula. When missionaries, merchants, and later plantation laborers from Japan, China, Portugal, and the Philippines arrived, Hawaiian food absorbed their influences without ever loosening its grip on the earth oven.

You may not have a pit of glowing stone in the backyard, but the heart of the method—salt, smoke, patience, and the intent to feed a crowd—carries into any kitchen. When the meat finally gives way at the touch of a fork, tender and richly savory, it does what it has always done: it turns an ordinary afternoon into an occasion, and a table of guests into something much closer to family.

KALUA PORK

Cooked for hours beneath hot volcanic stones and banana leaves in an underground imu, Kalua pork has been the smoky centerpiece of Hawaiian lu'au celebrations for a thousand years.

Yield: 8–12 servings

INGREDIENTS

- 4–6 lb. pork shoulder (or pork butt)
- 1 ½ to 2 Tbsp Hawaiian sea salt (or kosher salt)
- 1 Tbsp liquid smoke (mesquite or hickory flavor)
- Banana leaves or ti leaves for lining/wrapping (optional, for authentic aroma)

INSTRUCTIONS

TRADITIONAL-STYLE (OVEN METHOD)

1. *Prepare the pork*: Rinse and pat the pork shoulder, or butt if using, dry. Rub all sides generously with Hawaiian salt, then rub liquid smoke evenly over the pork. Optional: wrap the pork in banana or ti leaves, then in foil, for extra flavor and moisture (not required but authentic).
2. *Roast*: Preheat the oven to 300°F (150°C). Place the pork in a large roasting pan or Dutch oven with a lid (or cover tightly with foil) and roast for 4–5 hours, or until the meat is very tender and shreds easily with a fork.
3. *Shred and serve*: Remove from the oven, discard any large fat pieces, and shred the pork with forks. Mix in some of the rendered juices for moisture and flavor.

NOTES & TIPS

- Slow Cooker Method (easier option): Rub the pork with salt and liquid smoke as above. Place in a slow cooker and cook on LOW for 8–10 hours, or until tender. Shred and mix with some of the juices before serving.

